

Discovery-Call Question List

What to ask on a first call, grouped by purpose, with what a good answer sounds like.

A discovery call's job is to find out whether — and how — you can actually help, before either of you discusses price or scope. These questions are grouped by what they're for, with a note on why each one matters and what a strong answer versus a red-flag answer tends to sound like.

A — Current situation and pain

Question	Why it matters	Good sign vs. red flag
"Walk me through how you currently handle [the task/process]?"	Reveals their actual workflow, not the one you assumed.	Strong: specific, step-by-step. Red flag: "we don't really have a set way of doing it" (often means no one owns the problem).
"What's the most time-consuming or frustrating part of that?"	Finds the real pain, which is often different from the first thing they mention.	Strong: a specific, recurring moment. Red flag: a shrug — may mean it isn't painful enough yet to pay to fix.
"What have you already tried to fix this?"	Shows how seriously they've taken the problem, and what's already failed.	Strong: a real attempt with a clear reason it fell short. Red flag: nothing tried despite describing it as a big problem.

B — Goals and what success looks like

Question	Why it matters	Good sign vs. red flag
"If this were solved three months from now, what would actually be different day to day?"	Gets a concrete picture of success instead of a vague wish.	Strong: a specific, observable change. Red flag: can't describe any difference at all.
"Is this urgent, or something you've been meaning to get to for a while?"	Separates real, funded urgency from a nice-to-have idea.	Strong: a clear reason it matters now. Red flag: "just thinking about it" with no driving event.

C — Decision-making and budget signals

Question	Why it matters	Good sign vs. red flag
"Who else, if anyone, would be involved in deciding to move forward with something like this?"	Tells you whether you're talking to the actual decision-maker.	Strong: a clear, short answer ("just me" or one named person). Red flag: a long, vague chain of approvals for a small project.

Question	Why it matters	Good sign vs. red flag
"Would something like this need a separate budget approval, or is that already covered?"	Surfaces whether paying is even possible without a longer process.	Strong: a direct answer either way. Red flag: visible discomfort or avoidance of the question entirely.

D — Timeline

Question	Why it matters	Good sign vs. red flag
"Is there a date this needs to be in place by?"	Tells you whether there's a real deadline driving the decision.	Strong: a specific date tied to a reason. Red flag: "whenever" with no reason given.

E — Wrap-up

Question	Why it matters	Good sign vs. red flag
"Looking back after this call, what would have made it a waste of your time?"	Surfaces unstated expectations before they become a disappointment later.	Strong: a specific concern you can address now. Red flag: "nothing, this was great" with no real engagement during the call.
"What questions do you have for me?"	A genuine question list from them is a sign of real interest, not politeness.	Strong: specific, practical questions. Red flag: none at all.

Not every question fits every call — use judgment about which ones apply. The goal of a discovery call is clarity, for both sides, about whether to move forward — not to extract a yes on the spot.